



From idea to implementation

We tell you about everything from business plans and vision statements to pitching and VCs, from market research to valuations. Basically, all that you'll ever need to know about taking your startup from the mere seed of an idea to stellar success



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We're pretty sure last month's cover story inspired you like Leonidas inspired his 300 to defy all odds and charge through the hills. While you didn't slay any Persians (we hope), you probably put on your thinking cap last month and came up with that one startup idea to rule them all. An idea that will dramatically alter the world as we know it. An idea so big even Zuckerberg will sit up and take notice!

But hold on, let's not book that Ferrari just yet. An idea is just the starting point. Strap in...the ride has just begun.

Create a stellar business plan Formulate a sound strategy and vision statement

As Sam Altman of Y Combinator says, "Good execution is 100 times more important than a good idea and more difficult". The first step to good execution is a well documented business plan. Most founders, however, especially the geeks, spend more time on product development than on a strategy. Unless you've designed

a product like the Tesla car or Twitter, you'll need to have a sound strategy in place (no disrespect to Elon Musk and Tesla, they do have a great strategy).

Since a business plan is considered as a blueprint to your success, it can be a daunting task. A mind map tool like 'Mindmeister.com' can help you get your thoughts in order and eventually hash them out into a cohesive plan. An important point to note is that there will be several iterations of the plan as you progress.

There are several components of a good business plan. A good vision statement is crucial. Everybody – your investor, employee and consumer – gets behind something that's larger than life, something that includes and inspires them. It should encompass a dream, a solution. Chew on Amazon's mission statement: "Our vision is to be earth's most customer centric company; to build a place where people can come to find and discover anything they might want to buy online."

Coming back to formulating a strategy, you need to remember that the devil is in the details. Talk about your product in depth. As you hash it out, you'll discover some of the important points you missed and redundancies that are present. The next step is to do a thorough competitive analysis. Know thy enemy is the mantra given to us by Sun Tzu in the now immortal Art of War. It one of the cornerstones of victory in any battle.

Advertise your product, because it won't sell itself

Marketing strategy is another commonly ignored aspect. Say, you're a tech guy – the coder who's built this revolutionary app,